contracts were signed each year. This was, therefore, the Brazilian contractors' richest period of international expansion. Accounting for this success were the international economic recovery at the end of the 1980s and beginning of the 1990s, the opening of world markets at the end of the Cold War, the expansion of the regional economic integration process (European Union and NAFTA) and capital globalisation as well as Brazilian government incentives for companies to internationalise and the greater competitiveness of domestic firms. This was a period of low growth for the Brazilian economy and a crisis in the public works sector. In any case, this was not very different from the previous period (pre-1988) and the one afterwards (post-1997). In the final analysis, what seem to explain this cycle of Brazilian contractor expansion abroad in the ten years between 1988 and 1997 are short-term international market conditions associated with the fact of having huge and experienced Brazilian civil engineering firms that had maintained state support even after the dictatorship had ended.

Yet, by the second half of the 1990s, a series of national and international economic shocks occurred. The 1997 Asian crisis followed by the Russian setback in 1998 and the Brazilian one in 1999 checked the international public works market and the momentum of the Brazilian contractors' international expansion. The second half of Fernando Henrique Cardoso government's term was marked by a severe economic recession that affected Brazilian civil engineering firms and their overseas activities. Thus the period 1996–2003 was noted for a certain retraction of the transnationalisation process of Brazilian contractors in the face of deteriorating national and international economic conditions.

The previous era was when Brazilian contractors had signed the greatest number of foreign contracts. In this light, the Lula period (2003–10) was distinguished by the recovery of the Brazilian economy, by the growth of the international economy led by new development centres and by being an era when Brazilian heavy construction firms expanded their activities abroad. If the growth of all BRICS members in this period, especially the Chinese economy, did not directly generate opportunities for public works in them, it did stimulate projects, particularly in logistics, in regions such as Latin America and Africa. Also important were the projects of the Initiative for the Integration of the Regional Infrastructure of South America (IIRSA) and the rise in petroleum prices (due to American wars in the Middle East) that caused a growth of the market for public works in such oil-producing countries as Venezuela, an important area for Brazilian contractor activity. Besides the positive domestic and international scenario, a decisive factor for grasping this expansion was broad state support and favourable public policies. BNDES lines of credit and Brazilian